

A single CCD camcorder starts from Rs 16,000 while a three CCD camcorder will cost at least Rs 70,000

standard VHS, but the audio quality is slightly better. 8mm tapes come with a capacity of two hours of footage. If you want play 8mm tapes on your TV, attach your camcorder to the TV set, and simply use it as a VCR.

Hi-8

Hi-8 camcorders are also analogue, and are quite similar to 8mm camcorders. There are some important differences, though. Hi-8 camcorders have a much higher resolution—about 400 lines. Hi-8 tapes cost much more than 8mm tapes.

MiniDV

MiniDV cassettes store videos digitally in the DV format, which is superior to any other format. MiniDV is widely supported by most camcorders and enjoys a wide acceptance by video editing software. A very good compression ratio ensures that high-quality recording takes only a small amount of space. Audio is recorded as 12- or 16-bit pulse-code modulated (PCM) signal with a



A MicroMV camera is very small indeed

facility to add audio dubbing information. The DV format uses the DCT method for compression which, in terms of hard disk space, requires 3.5 MB for each second of video recorded. A MiniDV camcorder can store 60 to 90 minutes of footage, it can also take still pictures, much like a camera.

Digital8

Just like MiniDV, the Digital8 digital format stores video in DV format, thus providing similar quality and resolution. But the storage medium used here is the less expensive Hi8 cassette which can store about 60 minutes of footage. Another advantage associated is that it is compatible with many video editing software as well as hardware like decks.



A camcorder using a Mini-DVD format for recording

MicroMV

MicroMV allows for very compact camcorders. It stores video in the MPEG2 format which is a popular digital format, recognised by almost any software. A MicroMV cassette is very expensive. Since MicroMV does not store video in the common DV format, one is dependent on bundled software to convert the video to DV or other formats. The MicroMV format also provides less storage space as compared to MiniDV.

Mini-DVD-R/RW/RAM

The recording format is MPEG-2, but the digital media involved here provides more reliable, convenient and portable storage. Since the medium is about three-quarters of a standard DVD-ROM, one can play the recorded movie directly on DVD players.

Note that if the camcorder supports DVD-RAM, you might need a compatible DVD player (See page 40 of the September 2004 issue of *Digit* to understand various DVD media.) This medium provides 30 to 120 minutes of footage.

DVCAM

DVCAM is a proprietary digital format from Sony which provides better quality by running the cassette at a higher speed. One subset of the DVCAM is the MiniDVCAM which provides shorter recording time compared to DVCAM, but offers the flexibility of recording on regular MiniDV cassettes. If you use standard MiniDV instead of MiniDVCAM, you would lose one-third of the recording time of the MiniDV cassette. So, if the MiniDV can record for 60 minutes, then while substituting for MiniDVCAM, it would only record 40 minutes.

In The Market

In the local market you will find camcorders ranging from approximately Rs 16,000 to Rs 2,00,000. Camcorders with Hi8-based cassettes are available for Rs 16,490, while ones with MiniDV support start at approximately Rs 30,000. Those with DVD support are priced around the Rs 60,000 mark.

All these models come with single CCD; the 3-CCD, three-chip camcorders start at Rs 70,000.

The major brands in the Indian market are Samsung, Sony, Panasonic, Canon and JVC. Digital camcorders start at around Rs 30,000 and go up as features and performance increase. ☐

mustali_kachwala@thinkdigit.com
ahmed_shaikh@thinkdigit.com



Other Essentials To Purchase

Headphone and MIC Depending upon your needs you may need to attach a high-quality MIC to record distortion-free. Some cameras have a built-in zoom for audio which follows the lens. Camcorders with XLR ports can be attached to professional audio equipment. Microphones to consider include the omni-directional and the shotgun.

Memory Card A memory card can help you download still images to the PC. Some camcorders can directly store stills to a memory card, saving space.

Extra Battery If you travel a lot, you might need an extra battery set

Tripod Mini tripods are available and are particularly helpful for landscape, portraits and wildlife photography.

Flash For capturing movies at night or under low-light conditions, the in-built flash might not be enough. Consider purchasing a more powerful, external one in that case.